

A **mantra** (/ˈmæntrə, ˈmʌn-/ *MAN*-*trə*, *MUN*-^[1] *Pali*: *mantra*) or **mantram** (*Devanagari*: मन्त्रम्)^[2] is a sacred utterance, a **numinous** sound, a syllable, word or **phonemes**, or group of words (most often in an **Indo-Iranian language** like **Sanskrit** or **Avestan**) believed by practitioners to have religious, magical or spiritual powers.^{[3][4]} Some mantras have a **syntactic structure** and a literal meaning, while others do not.^{[3][5]}

ॐ, ॐ (Aum, Om) serves as an important mantra in various **Indian religions**. Specifically, it is an example of a seed syllable mantra (**bijamantra**). It is believed to be the first sound in **Hinduism** and as the sonic essence of the absolute divine reality. Longer mantras are phrases with several syllables, names and words. These phrases may have spiritual interpretations such as a name of a deity, a longing for truth, reality, light, immortality, peace, love, knowledge, and action.^{[3][6]} Examples of longer mantras include the **Gayatri Mantra**, the **Hare Krishna mantra**, **Om Namah Shivaya**, the **Mani mantra**, the **Mantra of Light**, the **Namokar Mantra**, and the **Mūl Mantar**. Mantras without any actual linguistic meaning are still considered to be musically uplifting and spiritually meaningful.^[7]

The use, structure, function, importance, and types of mantras vary according to the school and philosophy of **Jainism**, **Buddhism**, **Hinduism**, **Zoroastrianism**, and **Sikhism**.^{[4][8]} A common practice is **japa**, the meditative repetition of a mantra, usually with the aid of a **mala** (prayer beads). Mantras serve a central role in the Indian **tantric traditions**, which developed elaborate **yogic** methods which make use of mantras.^{[7][9]} In tantric religions (often called "mantra paths", **Sanskrit**: **Mantranāya** or **Mantramarga**), mantric methods are considered to be the most effective path. **Ritual initiation** (**abhiseka**) into a specific mantra and its associated deity is often a requirement for reciting certain mantras in these traditions. However, in some religious traditions, initiation is not always required for certain mantras, which are open to all.^{[10][6]}

The word *mantra* is also used in English to refer to something that is said frequently and is deliberately repeated over and over.

Etymology and origins

The earliest mention of **mantras** is found in the **Vedas** of **ancient India** and the **Avesta** of **ancient Iran**.^[11] Both **Sanskrit mántra** and the **equivalent Avestan maθra** go back to the common **Proto-Indo-Iranian *mantram**, consisting of the **Indo-European *men** "to think" and the instrumental suffix ***trom**.^{[12][13][14][15][16]} Due to the linguistic and functional similarities, they must go back to the common **Indo-Iranian period**, commonly dated to around 2000 BCE.^{[17][18]}

Scholars^{[3][7]} consider the use of mantras to have begun in India before 1000 BC. By the middle [Vedic period](#) (1000 BC to 500 BC) – claims [Frits Staal](#) – mantras in Hinduism had developed into a blend of art and science.^[7]

The Chinese translation is 真言; *zhenyan*; 'true words', the Japanese [on'yomi](#) reading of the Chinese being [shingon](#) (which is also used as the proper name for the [Shingon sect](#)). According to Alex Wayman and Ryujun Tajima, "Zhenyan" (or "Shingon") means "true speech", has the sense of "an exact mantra which reveals the truth of the dharmas", and is the path of mantras.^{[19][20]}

According to Bernfried Schlerath, the concept of *sātyas mantras* is found in Indo-Iranian [Yasna](#) 31.6 and the [Rigveda](#), where it is considered structured thought in conformity with the reality or poetic (religious) formulas associated with inherent fulfillment.^[21]

Definition



Mantras written on a rock near [Namche Bazaar Nepal](#)

There is no generally accepted definition of mantra.^[22] As a result, there is a long history of scholarly disagreement on the meaning of mantras and whether they are instruments of mind, as implied by the etymological origin of the word *mantra*. One school suggests mantras are mostly meaningless sound constructs, while the other holds them to be mostly meaningful linguistic instruments of mind.^[6] Both schools agree that mantras have melody and a well designed mathematical precision in their construction and that their influence on the reciter and listener is similar to that is observed in people around the world listening to their beloved music that is devoid of words.^{[3][7]}

In Oxford Living Dictionary mantra is defined as a word or sound repeated to aid concentration in meditation.^[23] Cambridge Dictionary provides two different definitions. The first refers to Hinduism and Buddhism: a word or sound that is believed to have a special spiritual power. The second definition is more general: a word or phrase that is often repeated and expresses a particularly strong belief. For instance, a football team can choose individual words as their own "mantra."^[24]

[Louis Renou](#) has defined mantra as a thought.^[25] Mantras are structured formulae of thoughts, claims [Silburn](#).^[26] [Farquhar](#) concludes that mantras are a religious thought, prayer, sacred utterance, but also believed to be a spell or weapon of supernatural power.^[27] [Zimmer](#) defines mantra as a verbal instrument to produce something in one's mind.^[28] [Agehananda Bharati](#) defines mantra, in the context of the Tantric school of Hinduism, to be a combination of mixed genuine and quasi-morphemes arranged in conventional patterns, based on codified esoteric traditions, passed on from a guru to a disciple through prescribed initiation.^[29]

[Jan Gonda](#), a widely cited scholar on Indian mantras,^[30] defines mantra as general name for the verses, formulas or sequence of words in prose which contain praise, are believed to have religious, magical or spiritual efficiency, which are meditated upon, recited, muttered or sung in a ritual, and which are collected in the methodically arranged ancient texts of Hinduism.^[31] By comparing the [Old Indic Vedic](#) and [Old Iranian Avestan](#) traditions, Gonda concludes that in the oldest texts, mantras were "means of creating, conveying, concentrating and realizing intentional and efficient thought, and of coming into touch or identifying oneself with the essence of the divinity".^[3] In some later schools of Hinduism, Gonda suggests a mantra is sakti (power) to the devotee in the form of formulated and expressed thought.^[3]



[A Mantra Chant](#)

Duration: 6 minutes and 20 seconds (6:20)

A Buddhist mantra chant set to Indian classical music (6 minutes 19 seconds)^[32]

Problems playing this file? See [media help](#).

[Frits Staal](#) clarifies that mantras are not rituals, they are what is recited or chanted during a ritual.^[7] Staal^[7] presents a non-linguistic view of mantras. He suggests that verse mantras are metered and harmonized to mathematical precision (for example, in the *viharanam* technique), which resonate, but a lot of them are a hodgepodge of meaningless constructs such as are found in folk music around the world. Staal cautions that there are many mantras that can be translated and do have spiritual meaning and philosophical themes central to Hinduism, but that does not mean all mantras have a literal meaning. He further notes that even when mantras do not have a literal meaning, they do set a tone and ambiance in the ritual as they are recited, and thus have a straightforward and uncontroversial ritualistic meaning.^[7] The sounds may lack literal meaning, but they can have an effect. He compares mantras to bird songs, that have the power to communicate,

yet do not have a literal meaning.^[33] On that *saman* category of Hindu mantras, which Staal described as resembling the arias of [Bach](#)'s oratorios and other European classics, he notes that these mantras have musical structure, but they almost always are completely different from anything in the syntax of natural languages. Mantras are literally meaningless, yet musically meaningful to Staal.^[34] The *saman* chant mantras were transmitted from one Hindu generation to next verbally for over 1000 years but never written, a feat, suggests Staal, that was made possible by the strict mathematical principles used in constructing the mantras. These *saman* chant mantras are also mostly meaningless, cannot be literally translated as Sanskrit or any Indian language, but nevertheless are beautiful in their resonant themes, variations, inversions, and distribution.^[7] They draw the devotee in. Staal is not the first person to view Hindu mantras in this manner. The ancient Hindu Vedic ritualist Kautsa was one of the earliest scholars to note that mantras are meaningless; their function is phonetic and syntactic, not semantic.^[35]

Harvey Alper^[36] and others^[37] present mantras from the linguistic point view. They admit Staal's observation that many mantras do contain bits and pieces of meaningless jargon, but they question what language or text doesn't. The presence of an abracadabra bit does not necessarily imply the entire work is meaningless. Alper lists numerous mantras that have philosophical themes, moral principles, a call to virtuous life, and even mundane petitions. He suggests that from a set of millions of mantras, the devotee chooses some mantras voluntarily, thus expressing that speaker's intention, and the audience for that mantra is that speaker's chosen spiritual entity. Mantras deploy the language of spiritual expression, they are religious instruments, and that is what matters to the devotee. A mantra creates a feeling in the practicing person. It has an emotive numinous effect, it mesmerizes, it defies expression, and it creates sensations that are by definition private and at the heart of all religions and spiritual phenomena.^{[3][29][38]}